The story of these two periods is not exclusively about India–China relations. Developments that had nothing to do with India or China, or that did not necessarily impinge immediately and directly on India–China interactions, had a 'conditioning' effect – setting a context within which Delhi's and Beijing's dealings with each other occurred. In other words, India's and China's partnerships and their bilateral relations have to be understood as part of what academic historians call 'global history' – a larger history not entirely of their making. What is clear in this history is that contrary to their triumphalist narratives about themselves as being sturdily unaligned, neither has stood altogether alone. Whether their partnerships have served their interests is debatable, but that they have repeatedly chosen to partner either the USSR/Russia or the US is undeniable.

1949–1988: From Entente to Rivalry to Cold War Rivalry

During the Second World War, India, China, the USSR, and the US had been allies against the Japanese, with Indian forces fighting under British command. After its independence in 1947, India might have been expected to be closer to the US (given its Anglo-American political values and institutions) and China to the USSR (given the ideological convergence). In fact, non-aligned Delhi soon became resentful of the US, and aligned Beijing started to fall out with the Soviets. For a brief time, from 1954 to 1958, India and China (with the USSR) were in a tacit entente against the US. By the late 1950s, though, Moscow and Delhi were partnering against Beijing, and by 1969 China and the US were close to cementing a quasi-alliance against the Soviets. From then until 1988, India and China were Cold War rivals, on opposite sides of global politics, though from 1981–82 they began a détente of their own.